



Two of a kind: It takes phenomenal athleticism, versatility, and creativity to replicate Federer and Alcaraz, who successfully modelled his game after Federer, albeit with a two-handed backhand. REUTERS

consistency—in tennis history, extremely high-percentage shot selection, and an intimidating, never-say-die competitiveness. Sooner or later, these assets broke down opponents' strokes, bodies, and spirits.

In my view, Rafa's unique playing style will prove the hardest to emulate and master, particularly given that only about 10 per cent of world-class players are typically left-handed.

Greatest ever achievement

A British newspaper that regularly offers readers polls, recently asked: "What is the greatest achievement in the history of men's tennis?" The options were:

- ✦ Rafael Nadal winning the French Open 14 times
- ✦ Bjorn Borg's 49-match winning streak
- ✦ Roger Federer's 237 consecutive weeks as world No.1
- ✦ Novak Djokovic winning 24

Grand Slams

✦ Rod Laver winning all four Grand Slams in the same year

This analyst picks Djokovic's achievement for two reasons. First, total career Major titles on all surfaces matter much more than total career Major titles on any one surface — which is Nadal's astounding achievement. And the splendid Serb's all-time men's record matters much more than any winning streak. (Would you rather

« The greatest achievement' is distinctly different from the 'most unbreakable record' »